

Debugging the Default: Why “Just Speak Up” is Bad Advice

Handout: Small Moves That Change the Room

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A practical companion to the talk: four workplace defaults, what they cost, and one small move you can try the next time the room starts to run faster than the people in it.

Before you read this

Read this less as a checklist and more as a set of small interventions for rooms that run on autopilot. What looks like a personal struggle is often a design default doing its work.

The default is not neutral. It is cultural, structural, procedural, social, and sometimes technical. It is made of unspoken assumptions about speed, clarity, confidence, interruption, credibility, availability, and what a “normal” response looks like. Those assumptions create load - and the load is not shared equally. The closer you are to the room’s imagined default, the more the room feels neutral. The further away you are, the more cognitive, energetic, and emotional work it can take simply to stay in the game.

- **You often cannot redesign the workspace overnight.** Most of these moves work inside defaults you did not create. That still matters. A five-second habit that lowers the cost, ten times a day, begins to change what the room treats as normal.
- **“Affected” and “leading” are not separate categories of people.** The person running the room may also be carrying the load. If that is you, use both sides of this handout: the moves for yourself and the moves for the room.

The talk follows four defaults: speed, specification, decoding, and being heard. They show up in fast meetings, vague ownership, indirect feedback, moving screens, and moments where an idea only lands once someone else says it. The first three ask: how much load does the room create? The fourth asks: whose contribution does the room recognise? The moves below are starting points, not rules. Adapt them to the room you are actually in.

From the stage to the next meeting: choose one default, try one move, and notice what the room does differently.

1. Speed - the accelerating meeting

What might be happening: the work is not moving at the pace of the task. It is moving at the pace of the room. Threads drop faster than they can be caught, sorted, and placed. The issue is not that any single thought is too hard. It is that too many thoughts are open at the same time.

If it is you

- **Externalise the queue.** Keep a visible running note - physical or digital - for every new thread as it appears, instead of holding it in memory. You do not lose earlier questions when new ones arrive.
- **Pause the game out loud.** A simple phrase - “hold on, let me note that” - buys time without turning the pause into a personal explanation.
- **Batch your re-entry.** Agree with yourself, or say it in the room, that you will raise outstanding points at a fixed checkpoint - “before we move on, can I go back to X” - rather than trying to interject in real time.
- **Reset the board afterward.** Take five minutes after a fast meeting to re-sequence what actually needs action. Meeting speed and task priority are not the same thing.

If you run the room

- **Build in checkpoints.** Pause every 10-15 minutes to surface what has piled up. This caps how many threads can stack before there is a legitimate moment to unload them.
- **Separate generating from deciding.** Say explicitly when you are brainstorming versus committing, so people are not forced to filter idea-noise from decisions in real time.
- **Make the parking lot shared, not private.** A visible, projected list that anyone can add to - not something people quietly maintain for themselves.
- **Send a short written recap.** This does not just help one person. It re-levels the floor for everyone whose best processing happens after the meeting, not during it.

2. Specification - the underspecified prompt

What might be happening: the person has not failed to understand the request. The request may be missing its shape. Without scope, authority, or a definition of done, there is no clean place to put the block. Clarifying is not resistance. It is debugging the prompt.

Indirect feedback is often the same pattern in softer form: instead of clear information about what needs to change, the person receives hints, tone, silence, or atmosphere and is expected to turn that into action.

If it is you

- **Treat vague requests as a bug report, not a personal failing.** Ask directly for the missing parameters: “what would count as done here?” and “who has final say if we disagree?”
- **Keep a personal default checklist.** Scope, authority, deadline, definition of done - for any ambiguous task. Asking becomes routine, not an improvised risk each time.
- **Ask in writing if live feels risky.** A follow-up message - “just to confirm scope: is X included?” - usually carries less social cost than interrupting.

- **Name real ambiguity instead of absorbing it silently.** “There is no clear scope yet - I will flag it when I hit a boundary” sets expectations rather than leaving you to guess alone.

If you run the room

- **Spec-check before you hand work over.** Outcome, context, constraints, authority, definition of done. If those five are missing, “take ownership” is not an instruction yet.
- **Treat clarifying questions as the request being debugged,** not as pushback - the same reflex you would have toward a good AI prompt or a well-written ticket.
- **Make “ask again in writing” explicitly acceptable.** Say so, so people do not have to guess whether a follow-up will read as annoying.
- **Name open-ended work as open-ended.** “This is genuinely open; here is what we do know” is different - and kinder - than making ambiguity look like clarity.

3. Decoding - the moving screen

What might be happening: the screen is moving faster than accurate reading allows. Text, numbers, scrolling, and spoken explanation compete for attention. By the time the mismatch becomes clear, the room has already moved on - and asking it to move back can carry a cost.

If it is you

- **Ask for material in advance whenever there is a choice.** “Can you share the doc or sheet beforehand so I can look at it first?” is a reasonable request, not a special favour.
- **Normalise your own “scroll back” as a process step,** not an apology. A neutral, practised phrase - “can you hold there a second” - loses its weight the more routinely it is used.
- **Use what works for you without justifying it in the room.** Screen readers, zoom, colour overlays, recording the share to review after - these are workflow choices, not disclosures you owe anyone.
- **Say when real-time confirmation is not realistic.** “I need to look at this properly before I can confirm” is a complete answer.

If you run the room

- **Share screens and documents before the meeting by default** - not on request. This removes the need for anyone to ask.
- **Slow down where accuracy matters.** Build “any objections” moments after a pause, not while the screen is still moving.
- **Record and share screen-shares as standard practice.** Do this as a default process, not as an accommodation arranged for one person.
- **Accept “I need to check this properly and get back to you” as a complete answer** to “does that look right?” - do not read a delayed confirmation as a red flag.

4. Being heard - who gets to score

What might be happening: this is not a processing issue. The idea may already be in the room. The question is whether the room registers the voice that brought it there. The fix is not “speak louder.” The fix is to make the room track who said what.

If it is you

- **Name the pattern in real time, when it is safe to.** “I raised that a minute ago” - short, factual, not accusatory - just makes the repetition visible.
- **Build alliances before the meeting.** Brief a colleague with more standing on your point beforehand, so they can back it explicitly - “building on what X said” - rather than re-presenting it as their own.
- **Put ideas in writing, timestamped,** wherever you can - chat, doc, ticket. Not to prove a point later, but because written ideas are harder to silently reassign.
- **See the pattern for what it is.** If your point only lands after someone else repeats it, that is not a personal failure of assertiveness. It is a room pattern.

If you run the room

- **Attribute ideas out loud, on the spot.** “That is the point X raised earlier - let us go back to it” costs nothing and directly interrupts the pattern.
- **Watch your own meetings for the pattern.** Track who gets interrupted, who gets built on immediately, and whose points get restated by someone else before they land. This is observable, not just a vague feeling.
- **Create a structural response requirement.** Every raised point gets a visible response - “noted,” “let us park it,” “yes, let us do that” - regardless of who raised it.
- **Catch the pattern when it runs through you.** If you realise you have just restated what someone else said and it suddenly landed, name it: “that is what X just said.” Small move. Real effect.

Appendix: Research background

The concepts in this talk are not invented from scratch - they connect to several established research traditions. None of them use the term “default worker,” but together they cover most of the ground.

On the “default worker” itself

- Acker, J. (1990). *Hierarchies, Jobs, Bodies: A Theory of Gendered Organizations*. Gender & Society, 4(2). - The foundational argument that a seemingly neutral job description already encodes a gendered, classed, racialized body and life situation.
- Williams, J. (2000). *Unbending Gender: Why Family and Work Conflict and What to Do About It*. Oxford University Press. - Develops the “ideal worker norm”: the expectation of full-time, uninterrupted availability with no competing obligations.
- Müller, J., & Chung, H. (2026). *From the Ideal Worker to the Inclusive Worker: Measuring Norm Shifts Within Occupational Contexts*. Gender, Work &

Organization, 33(1), 261-276. - Proposes the “inclusive worker” as an explicit counter-norm: one that accepts a plurality of devotions and does not assume a single default body or life.

On masking and cognitive cost

- Hull, L. et al. (2017). *“Putting on My Best Normal”: Social Camouflaging in Adults with Autism Spectrum Conditions*. Journal of Autism and Developmental Disorders. - Finds that masking behaviour predicts mental health outcomes more strongly than autism severity itself.
- Pryke-Hobbes, A., Davies, J., Heasman, B., Livesey, A., Walker, A., Pellicano, E., & Remington, A. (2023). *The Workplace Masking Experiences of Autistic, Non-Autistic Neurodivergent and Neurotypical Adults in the UK*. PLOS ONE, 18(9), e0290001. - Compares workplace masking across autistic, non-autistic neurodivergent, and neurotypical adults; shows masking as a protective strategy against negative social and employment consequences, not as an autism-specific behaviour.

On invisible work

- Star, S. L. & Strauss, A. (1999). *Layers of Silence, Arenas of Voice: The Ecology of Visible and Invisible Work*. Computer Supported Cooperative Work. - Coins “articulation work” and distinguishes visible work done by invisible people from invisible work done by visible people.
- Hochschild, A. R. (1983). *The Managed Heart: Commercialization of Human Feeling*. University of California Press. - The original account of “emotional labour” - managing one’s own affect as an unrecognised part of the job.

On who gets heard

- Fricker, M. (2007). *Epistemic Injustice: Power and the Ethics of Knowing*. Oxford University Press. - Defines testimonial injustice: being denied credibility as a source of knowledge because of who you are, not because of what you said. Also defines “pre-emptive testimonial injustice” - when someone’s input is not even sought in the first place.

On cognitive load as a design variable, not a personal trait

- Sweller, J. (1988). *Cognitive Load During Problem Solving: Effects on Learning*. Cognitive Science, 12(2), 257-285. - Introduces cognitive load theory and shows how instructional or task design can consume working-memory capacity that would otherwise support learning.

None of this needs to be cited on stage - it is here for anyone who wants to go deeper after the talk.

No single move redesigns the system overnight. But small moves, repeated often, teach the room a new default. That is the work: not heroic transformation, but better defaults - built where we stand, by the people who notice.